PROJECT SUMMARY · DEMOGRAPHY

Demographic Analysis of Mantua, 2002–2024

Sofia Menegozzo · BSc Statistics and Information Management, University of Milano-Bicocca

≈ 49,700
residents at the end of 2024

+1,002
net migration in 2024

1.16
children per woman (2024)

−19%
projected population by 2045

Question

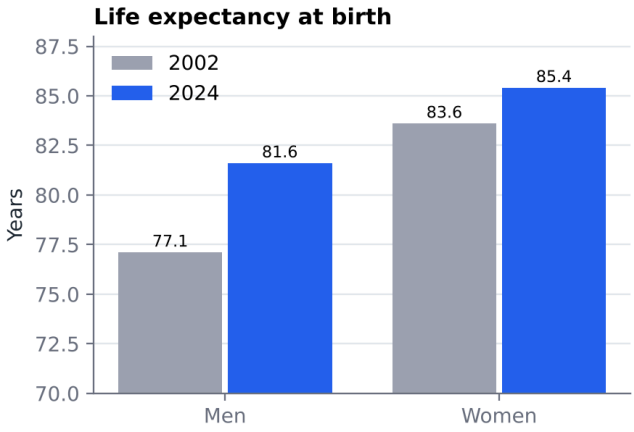
Mantua, a mid-sized Lombard city and UNESCO World Heritage site, has remained close to 50,000 inhabitants for two decades. This project looks behind that apparent stability: how have population size, age structure, mortality, fertility and migration changed since 2002, and what do projections imply for the next twenty years? All indicators and projections were built in a spreadsheet from municipal demographic data.

Population dynamics

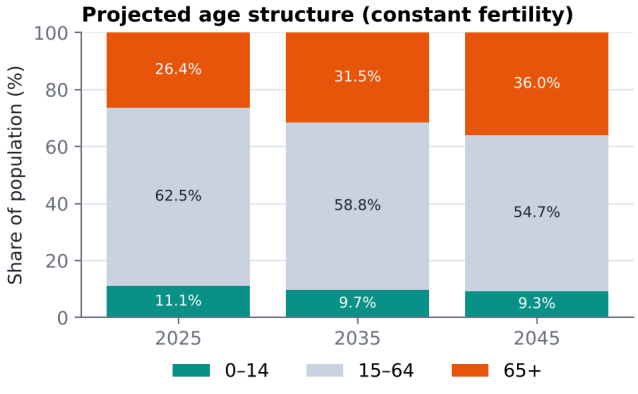
The population followed three phases: a slight decline from 2002 to 2010, a strong recovery from 2010 to 2018 (+1,627) and slower growth afterwards. Deaths have exceeded births in almost every year (a natural balance of −498 in 2020), so growth comes entirely from migration. Since 2008 the net migration balance has been consistently positive and reached +1,002 in 2024, with gains from both other Italian municipalities and abroad. While Italy has been shrinking since 2014, Mantua has kept growing.

Ageing, mortality and longevity

Comparing the 2002 and 2024 age pyramids, the large adult cohorts born during the post-war boom have moved up into the 50–70 age range, the over-80 group has expanded and the working-age population has narrowed. Mortality is very low up to age 40 and rises steeply after 75. Life expectancy at birth rose from 77.1 to 81.6 years for men and from 83.6 to 85.4 for women, so the gender gap fell from 6.5 to 3.8 years; at age 65, men gained almost three years.



Life expectancy at birth, Mantua.



Projected age structure, 2025–2045.

Fertility

Women have children later (mean age at birth above 32) and fewer of them: the total fertility rate peaked at 1.61 in 2010 and fell back to 1.16, with about 6 births per 1,000 residents in 2024. At the

same time the number of women aged 15–49 is shrinking, so even stable fertility would mean fewer births.

Projections

Under constant fertility, the population is projected to fall from about 49,700 to about 40,200 by 2045. The share of residents aged 65 and over rises from 26% to 36%, children fall below 10% of the population, and the working-age share drops from 62.5% to 54.7%. The implications are a heavier load on health and welfare services, fewer pupils and more empty housing.

Conclusion

Mantua is not in absolute decline, but it is ageing and grows only thanks to people moving in. Its future depends on supporting births, attracting young residents and families, and adapting services and urban space to an older population.

> Limitations: projections assume today's fertility, mortality and migration patterns continue unchanged; a change in any of them would alter the scenario. English summary of the full report, which is written in Italian (analisi_demografica_mantova.pdf); charts were redrawn with English labels from the figures reported in the analysis.